

Judges 3

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Sermon IV. Judges 3:5-11

"And the children of Israel dwelt among the Canaanites, and Hittites, and Amorites, and Perizzites, and Hivites, and Jebusites: and they took their daughters to be their wives, and gave their daughters to their sons, and served their gods. And the children of Israel did evil in the sight of the Lord, and forgot the Lord their God, and served Baalim and the groves. Therefore the anger of the Lord was hot against Israel, and he sold them into the hand of Chushan-rishathaim king of Mesopotamia: and the children of Israel served Chushan-rishathaim eight years. And when the children of Israel cried unto the Lord, the Lord raised up a deliverer to the children of Israel, who delivered them, even Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother. And the Spirit of the Lord came upon him, and he judged Israel, and went out to war: and the Lord delivered Chushan-rishathaim king of Mesopotamia, into his hand; and his hand prevailed against Chushan-rishathaim. And the land had rest forty years." (Judges 3:5-11)

It has been endeavoured in some former discourses from this book of Judges, to give a general idea of the nature of the history which it contains. We have seen, that when we regard the whole of the Divine Word as describing the progress of individual regeneration, as no doubt it does, from the first formation of the human being to his highest state of advancement; the histories of this book must have reference to those states which supervene, after man has attained the elevated situation of a truly spiritual man, represented by his establishment in the land of Canaan, and when new openings of the recesses of his nature are made to him, which are necessary to the further extension of his acquirements, and without which he could never attain the state in which are the angels of the highest heavens, and become a truly celestial being.

With respect however to the more general manner in which these histories may be regarded, we have seen that they describe states of the church at large, when it suffers itself to fall away from the principle of its foundation, and inclines to the evils and false persuasions which are inherent in the mind of man, and which are called into activity by the influence of evil spirits, who, when considered in one aggregate, are called the devil, of whom an apostle declares, that he is ever going about as a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.

We read in this book of six great oppressions which the Israelites suffered from the idolatrous nations around them, or from those whom they permitted to dwell among them, each of which lasted for a considerable number of years. The first is that related in our text, when the king of Mesopotamia held them in bondage for eight years, until they were delivered by the raising up of Othniel for the purpose. After his death, when the Israelites lapsed again into idolatrous practices, they were subdued by the Moabites, under whose tyranny they groaned for eighteen years, and were delivered by Ehud. After some trouble from the Philistines, who were overthrown by Shamgar, they again did evil in the sight of the Lord, (as is often remarked;) when they were oppressed by Jabin, a Canaanitish prince, and by Sisera, the captain of his forces, for the long space of twenty years; until Deborah and Barak were raised up for their deliverance. They next fell under the power of the Midianites, and were by them reduced to the greatest extremity of distress, for the period of seven years; when they were rescued by the extraordinary exploits of Gideon and his curiously selected band of three hundred men. After his days, except that they suffered from the domestic tyranny of his son Abimelech, they seem to have enjoyed a considerable interval of tranquility under two pacific judges, Tola and Jair; when they were enslaved by the Ammonites for eighteen years, and were rescued by Jephthah. He was succeeded by

three judges, of whom little is recorded, when the Philistines obtained the dominion over them; and whose power, notwithstanding the great exploits of Samson, was not completely broken until the reign of David.

Thus this book contains the history of the Israelitish nation under the authority of twelve Judges, and of their sufferings under six complete states of subjugation to different nations: in which, however, I have not reckoned their captivity to the Philistines in the days of Shamgar, because this seems to have been but of very partial extent. Of all these, that related in our text (except that connected with Shamgar) is passed over the most briefly. All the others are accompanied with details of considerable length, and some very singular circumstances attended all the means by which deliverance was obtained; whereas, in that at present before us, nothing peculiarly remarkable seems to have distinguished the war which was undertaken by Othniel, further than that Chushan-rishathaim appears to have been easily vanquished. The causes, however, which led to this captivity, are detailed more at length than in most other instances, no doubt to serve as a general introduction to the whole, and to let us know what is included in the brief expression generally used on other occasions — "*the children of Israel did evil in the sight of the Lord.*" We will note the chief circumstances stated, which will lead us briefly to explain what is meant by the several nations mentioned; what by the kind of alliances which the Israelites contracted with them; what by the anger of the Lord being kindled against Israel; what by their slavery under Chushan-rishathaim; what by their crying to the Lord; and what by their deliverance through the instrumentality of Othniel.

With respect to the first of these subjects, it is said, that the children of Israel dwelt in the midst of the Canaanites, Hittites, and Amorites, and Perizzites, and Hivites, and Jebusites; which are the same that are mentioned elsewhere as being the nations whom the Israelites were to drive out of the land, and by no means to tolerate among them. The wicked natives of the land of Canaan represent the deep-seated evil lusts and false persuasions inherent in the human heart; and no doubt, when they are enumerated in a series, as in the present case, they denote all the corruptions, in a general complex, to which the heart of man is prone. Each one of them, we may be assured, expresses some general class of depraved affections of the will, or false suggestions of the understanding; though how to distinguish in what they differ from each other would perhaps require nicer degrees of spiritual discrimination than we at present possess.

The Canaanites usually denote evil in general; but sometimes, when mentioned in connexion with others, they denote that kind of evil which is the result of a man's having previously confirmed himself in false principles of belief. Let us suppose, for instance, a man to be persuaded, as multitudes are, that faith alone is all that is requisite for salvation, and that charity and good works, though useful in society, are of no use whatever in promoting man's justification in the sight of God; — if, under the persuasion that charity or good will not save him, he should begin to think that neither will evil condemn him, and should thus become regardless of the state of his affections, and live in the practice of whatever his corrupt natural inclinations suggest: — such a man is sunk in evil grounded in falsity; — he indulges in evil in consequence of having imbibed, as a principle of doctrine, the notion that faith alone is sufficient, and that where this is possessed, sins do not appear in the sight of God.

So again the Hittites represent such false persuasions in the understanding as give birth to evil indulgences; and these are such notions as just explained respecting the all-sufficiency of faith alone:

and many other false notions, whose tendency is similar, exist. The doctrine, for instance, of man's being destitute of free will in spiritual things is a false persuasion that has a direct tendency to beget evil in affection and practice: for he that believes it, will readily say, "If I cannot do good or abstain from, evil without an irresistible outpouring of divine grace, and this grace is not given me, I cannot be to blame, let me do what I may:" — and so such a person will indulge in all evil propensities, while in his heart he imputes the blame of them to God. Such notions are spiritual Hittites; to contract an alliance with which is to rebel against the Lord, and to forsake his pure worship for the worship of idols.

The Amorites again represent evil in general, specifically such as captivates the external man; as appears from their having their chief residence on the outside of Jordan, where, with their king Sihon, they were vanquished by Moses.

The Perizzites, which are next mentioned, denote false persuasions originating in evil of heart, as all false notions originally do, although when once invented, they may be infused into other persons, who may hold them in simplicity, and thus not be sharers in the criminality which is incurred by the inventors of them. Thus, whenever a man is attached to the practice of evil of any kind whatever, though at first he may be sensible that it is very wrong, yet if he does not on this account desist from it, he is sure by practice so to confirm it as to lose all wish to desist from it; and as in such case the thought that it is wrong becomes disagreeable and painful, he first frames for himself some excuse, and at last actually persuades himself that he has a right to do as he does: and this persuasion is truly the falsity grounded in evil — it is false in itself, and evil is its author. And such notions as these are constantly meant by the Perizzites wherever they are spoken of in the Holy Word.

The other two classes mentioned — the Hivites and the Jebusites, — also denote evil inclinations and false imaginations, but such as are of a milder kind than the others, as partaking more of ignorance than of intention: but such as are nevertheless highly culpable in a man who, having the Holy Word to consult, and the means of obtaining correct ideas as to its doctrines, neglects these advantages, and following his own inclinations and blind conceptions without caring to have them set right, falls into the idolatry of regarding external things in preference to internal, thinking much of this life and little of any other.

Such then, are in general the things represented by the six nations here mentioned. Of course it is easy to see how great is the wickedness described by the mode in which the Israelites contracted alliances with them, which is what we are in the second place to notice. It is said that "they took their daughters to be their wives, and gave their daughters to their sons, and served their Gods."

Daughters, whenever they are spoken of in the Word, denote **affections either of good or of evil**, and sons denote perceptions of truth. As the Israelites signify the members of the church — or, specifically that which constitutes the church in man, — for them to take the daughters of these wicked nations for wives, denotes the conjunction of the holy things of the Church with evil affections of all kinds; so again, to give their daughters to the sons of the wicked nations, is to unite affections of a heavenly origin with false persuasions.

For example: whoever, on the one part, has acquired an acquaintance with the genuine truths of the Church, knowing that there is a God, and who He is, that there is a heaven and hell, and the numerous doctrines that arise out of these general principles;

- and who does, notwithstanding, encourage **affections of an evil nature** in his heart, especially if he endeavours to make these heavenly things conducive to worldly and selfish ends,
 - he does what is represented by the Israelites marrying the **daughters of the Canaanites**: he profanes heavenly things, by mixing them with **selfish affections**.

On the other hand:

- whoever, in consequence of being acquainted with the truths of the Church, has felt **affections for these truths**, and for the Divine realities to which they relate, springing up in his mind;
 - if, for instance, on hearing the doctrine of the Lord unfolded, he has been struck with its reasonableness and beauty, and has **felt a delight** in it;
 - or if, on hearing of the nature of the heavenly world, he has been **sensible of a desire** arising in his heart to be enabled to enjoy the bliss described;
- these **delights and desires** are daughters of Israel: —
 - should he then afterwards embrace any of the specious but false sentiments, either of a nature directly doctrinal or not, which have their origin in the evils of the natural man;
 - should he combine his heavenward aspirations with such notions as these, applying, for instance, his delight on hearing of the Lord and his salvation, to the notion that He is but one of three Divine persons;
 - or seeking to gratify his longing for heaven by adopting the persuasion that heaven will be opened to him by mere faith, without regard to amendment of life;
 - — or should he in any other way unite **the affections that have been produced in his mind by a knowledge of spiritual things**, with any persuasions of a false and especially of a worldly and selfish nature;
- he then does what is meant by the Israelites giving their **daughters** in marriage to the sons of the Canaanites.

Such marriages, of both kinds, denote the combination of doctrines that are true with affections that are evil, by which the *truth becomes falsified*; and the combination of affections originally good with doctrines that are false, by which the *good becomes adulterated*.

When this is done, the transition is not great to the state represented by the serving, by the Israelites, of the Gods of the Canaanites; — by which is meant, to place the worldly and selfish things represented by the idolatrous nations so high in our affections, as to allow them the station due to the Lord alone.

The proper residence of the Lord with man is in the inmost of his mind; but if man's affections are set upon unworthy and evil objects, man's true spiritual internal, where the Lord resides, is not open; all that is open in such a man's mind is a region beneath; and whatever is the object of his supreme regard occupies the inmost or highest station therein; and this is to him, whether he suspects it or not, his God. Whoever, then, devotes his supreme affections to evil pursuits, worships in reality the gods of the Canaanites and the other idolatrous nations.

Now when a man has gone into this extent of transgression, he inevitably will experience what is called in the Holy Word, the anger of the Lord. It is said, "Therefore the anger of the Lord was hot against Israel"; by which is meant, not that the Lord really burns with anger, however deserving of it man may be; but that, when a man has suffered evil influences to turn him away from the Lord, so that in his heart, instead of the Lord, he worships some depraved affection, he comes into a state of such contrariety to the Lord, that everything proceeding from the Lord is perceived by him as something just the reverse of what it really is.

The change is not in the Lord, but in the man. In the Lord is nothing but love and wisdom, goodness and truth; and nothing but these ever can flow from Him; but when man has averted himself from these Divine graces, and has filled his mind with their opposites, then the Lord's love will appear to him like anger, and the influx of it, instead of recreating his soul with life and enjoyment, as it does when received by the angels, fills him with horror and dismay, occasioning to him such torment as he conceives cannot be the result of any thing but anger.

The case to the sinner is thus exactly the same as if the Lord were really full of anger against him, and this should ever be recollected; otherwise the doctrine that the Lord is nothing but love, would be liable to perversion and abuse. The case to the sinner and his feelings, is exactly the same as it would be if the Lord were really angry and punished him from a motive of vengeance; whereas the appearance of anger and vengeance arises from the state of the sinner alone. He has induced such a state on the spiritual organization of his mind, that pure Divine love and goodness, being things that in reality he hates, occasion to him pain by their presence. Hence all in hell, when they have any thought of the Lord at all, think of Him with hatred, and believe their wretched state to proceed from anger in Him, instead of being, as it is, the inseparable consequence of their own state of evil; of their opposition and aversion to every thing that is good.

The consequence of this state, in reference to the particular subjects treated of in our text, is declared to be that the Israelites were delivered into the hand of Chushan-rishathaim, king of Mesopotamia, who held them in bondage for eight years. Mesopotamia is that part of the ancient country of Syria which lies between the two rivers Euphrates and Tigris. Mesopotamia is its Greek name, applied to it in reference to its situation, as it denotes "in the midst of the rivers". Its name in Hebrew expressed the same thing: it was "Aram Naharaim", or "Syria of two rivers." Syria is very often mentioned in the Word, and it always denotes, in the spiritual sense, the knowledges of goodness and truth, either genuine or in a state of perversion.

The truths of the Church are called 'knowledges' while they abide in the memory, but are not appropriated in the life, in which case they are in reality without the man and not within him; just as the country of Syria lay without and not within the land of Canaan, to which it was contiguous.

To come, then, under the dominion of the king of Mesopotamia, is to come into a state in which the truths of the church, being no longer alive in us through being lived or loved, only exist as mere knowledges in the memory.

And when they even are falsified, so as to be made, by wrong interpretations, to appear to confirm the falsities and evils of the natural man; — In this state, the truths of the church, and whatever has been received in the mind from the Lord, are in reality made vile slaves.

This at length the children of Israel felt and deplored; which is represented by its being said that "they cried to the Lord". It is remarkable that this phrase is used on every occasion of the oppression of the Israelites recorded in this book, and in numerous other instances; as when the children of Israel were oppressed in Egypt, it is said that "they cried, and their cry came up unto God." This denotes that when man is truly sensible of the state in which he is, and is sincerely desirous to be delivered from it — then, and not before, deliverance is afforded.

To "worship the gods of Canaan" is to give to evil affections, that place in the mind which is due only to the Lord.

To "cry to the Lord" is to look to Him for help, from the deepest recesses of the heart: actuated by an intensity of desire to escape from the thralldom of our corruptions.

Such desire, in reality, has the Lord within it: being a desire of which He is the author and man the receiver, though a free one; and which, thus coming from Him, is sure to reach to Him, and then deliverance will follow.

This deliverance is here described as wrought by Othniel, the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother; respecting whom as the conqueror of Kirjath-Sepher, we lately delivered a discourse. Suffice it then to state now, that by him is represented a principle of truth originating in good of an elevated order.

And by his [i.e. "its" (the principle of truth)] being raised up for the work by the Lord, is represented that when such a desire for deliverance as we have already described is excited, man is gifted in his mind with such a genuine principle of truth derived from good, and invested with such power from the Lord, as will speedily rescue his knowledges of truth from perversion, and restore his mind to order in obedience to the Lord.

Be it then our constant care to prevent our knowledges of Divine things from degenerating into mere knowledges undirected by any view to use. And if we at any time experience a tendency to such perversion, let us not be slow to cry unto the Lord, and to seek from Him such a principle of real truth from good as a governing impulse, as shall restore the state to order, and revive a genuine spiritual principle such as shall prevail through all our life and conduct, securing us for ever in our heavenly inheritance.

Sermon V. Judges 3:12-14

"And the children of Israel did evil again in the sight of the Lord: and the Lord strengthened Eglon the king of Moab against Israel, because they had done evil in the sight of the Lord. And he gathered unto him the children of Ammon, and Amalek, and went and smote Israel, and possessed the city of palm trees. So the children of Israel served Eglon the king of Moab eighteen years." (Judges 3:12-14)

When we endeavour to unfold in the slight degree in which we are enabled, a few of the innumerable mysteries which are involved in the regeneration of the individual member of the church,

it may be necessary now and then to introduce a word of caution, to prevent the simple mind from concluding too hastily, that the work of regeneration is so arduous and complicated a process, that there is no hope of ever being led through what it involves.

Whilst the recondite [internal -Ed.] meaning of the Holy Word is only brought forward as matter of curious discovery, and,

in unfolding the spiritual subjects which are contained under the covering of the letter, especially in such extraordinary histories as that of which our text is a part,

the chief object is to defend the divinity of the Holy book, and to prove its claims to be received as divinely inspired,

by shewing that it contains stores of wisdom within it which none but the Divine Mind could conceive,

— even the natural man may feel interested, and take delight, in the discussion.

Because in this case the heavenly treasures of the Holy Word appear as matters of deep yet amusing speculation; and the love of knowledge, which is a principle of the natural man, though the highest of which he is capable, is alone sufficient to make such speculations agreeable to us.

How powerful a principle the love of knowledge is, is proved by the labours of body and mind which men who make science their pursuit, will often undergo for its gratification;

whilst the melancholy fact that some of the most distinguished of them have been enemies to the revealed will of God, fully evinces [proves -Ed.] that the love of knowledge is one of the affections of the natural man;

though, as just observed, it is the highest of these affections, because it is eminently useful to the spiritual man,

being a principle implanted in our nature to serve as a means of our passing from the dominion of the natural man to that of the spiritual,

and without which this great object of our creation could not be accomplished.

Now it is inherent in the love of knowledge, to be more delighted with things of a recondite and abstruse nature than with such as are common, and plain, or with knowledges of a high, than with those of a low, order.

The more exalted the subject respecting which the means of acquiring knowledge are presented, the higher is the satisfaction with which the acquisition is made;

and hence, where the mind is not so closed against heavenly things as to deny their reality altogether,

knowledge respecting them is capable of affording a delight altogether similar to that experienced on making scientific attainments of an ordinary nature,

but with many persons more exquisite, because it is seen that they relate to more noble and exalted subjects.

Still this is a natural delight: it is the natural man, or the natural part of our frame which is affected by it; which, when it regards the profoundest arcana of the Holy Word merely in the light of curious information, feels no repugnance at hearing of it, and experiences in it a gratification similar in its nature to what it feels on hearing of new discoveries in science, or in reading the works of adventurous and intelligent travellers or of elegant historians.

But when, in addition to an exposition of some of the general spiritual contents of the Holy Word, an application is made of them to individual states, there is room to apprehend that some minds, even of those who have entered on the work of regeneration and are sincerely desirous to advance in it, may feel alarm at the apparent magnitude of the work;

and some may conclude, that if the knowledge of these things is necessary to their being safely experienced,

— as they feel little hope of attaining any sufficient share of such knowledge, —

so it will be vain for them to expect the blessings consequent upon passing through the states.

To guard against the depressing effect which such thoughts must have, it may only be necessary to be assured that they are not founded in truth. It is possible, I have no doubt, to attain a very high state in the regenerate life, without seeing distinctly the application of any great portion of the Holy Word to the states which may nevertheless have been experienced.

The Lord declares to the Israelites, at the conclusion of their journey through the wilderness, "*I led you by a way which ye knew not*", to instruct us that it is the Lord alone who regulates the steps of our progress, and that in order to arrive safely at the end of it, it is not necessary that we should have an exact knowledge of the way beforehand.

What we have to do is to acknowledge the Lord, (looking continually to Him as the sole Author of every thing that can tend to our true welfare,) and to keep his commandments, striving without remission to recede more and more from the love and practice of whatsoever is contrary to them, and to do

continually with more and more affection and diligence whatever they enjoin; and all the rest we may safely leave to the Lord to do for us.

When we have reached the desired haven, and especially when our faculties receive that improvement which is consequent upon our passing into the spiritual world, and going to our happy home in heaven, we shall be able to look back upon the road through which we have been led, and to see distinctly what spiritual associates or opponents attended us in the way; but in the mean time this is not practicable; as the Lord said, "*What I do ye know not now, but ye shall know hereafter*" (John 13:7)

There is then, no room for discouragement, let our present state be ever so low or weak, in seeing the magnitude of the process of regeneration. Let us remember that the kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed; when once it has obtained admission into our hearts, however inconsiderable our first attainments may be, its after growth is almost a matter of course;

that is, it will infallibly proceed to maturity, without any anxiety of ours about the result, provided we continue simply to practise what first implanted it within us,—that is, to look to the Lord and shun evils as sins against Him.

Besides, there are certain great resting places, as it were, in our route. Whoever enters on a spiritual course at all, and does not make shipwreck by the way, cannot, I apprehend, stop, until the contents of the greater part of the book of Genesis are fulfilled in him,—that is, until he attains the state described by the subordination of the land of Egypt under the authority of Joseph; in which case, should he die at that time, or even before its completion, he will attain a state of happiness in the lowest or first heaven.

If he goes beyond this, I apprehend there is no permanent abiding place for him until the contents of the remaining books of Moses, those of the book of Joshua, and of the first chapter of Judges, have been spiritually experienced by him; in which case, should he die at that time, or even before it, he will become an inhabitant of the second or spiritual heaven:

—for whoever departs from this world after a general stage is entered upon, but before it is finished, has it completed in the world of spirits before he is taken up into heaven.

It is not probable that many at the present day go beyond this. To be qualified for the spiritual heaven is a very high and glorious state. But we know that it is the wish of our heavenly Father to lead us further than even this. He would, if it were possible, raise us to absolute oneness with Himself, so as to impart to us all the divine perfections which constitute His own nature, in all their infinite fulness; but as this is impossible, He ardently desires to raise us to the highest state which a finite creature can be made capable of enjoying; and it is nothing but our own fearfulness and obstinacy which prevents the designs of His boundless love from taking effect.

Let us then, not be so unwise as to draw any matter for discouragement from the almost endless succession of states which are represented in the history of the children of Israel after their establishment in the promised land, but let us consider every new scene in which we find the Israelites engaged, not as an additional obstacle to be surmounted, and thus as a discouragement, but as a further height of glory to be obtained, and thus as a stimulus.

Most people believe that there will be a continual increase of perfection and blessedness going on for

ever in those who attain the regions of heavenly felicity; now there can be no increase in perfection in heaven but by the further and further removal of the seat of our affections from our selfish nature; and this is exactly what is to take place in us while here, and what is represented by the sufferings of the Israelites from their enemies, and their deliverances from them;

only there is this difference, that our advancement before we enter heaven is effected by means of conflicts and temptations; whereas, when our state is so far rendered complete as to admit of our being received into heaven, it will then advance without any struggles, and our eternal state will be truly that which is represented by the sabbath of rest.

But the basis from whence we commence this career of tranquil advancement there, will be that which is attained by our active advancement here; let us then set our minds upon the things that are before us, and from every history of the Word draw an incentive to our progress.

Our present text details the account of the enslavement of the Israelites by Eglon king of Moab; and it is followed by the description of the very singular circumstances attending the assassination of Eglon, which was the first step to the deliverance of Israel. Some of these particulars we propose to endeavour to elucidate in another discourse; at present we will offer such observations, as appear naturally to arise out of the words before us, and may tend to throw a light on the circumstances mentioned.

"The children of Israel did evil again," it is said, "in the sight of the Lord; and the Lord strengthened Eglon the king of Moab against Israel, because they had done evil in the sight of the Lord." What an important lesson do these words at the very first glance, convey.

They plainly instruct us that when we fall into spiritual captivity, so as to lose the freedom which is felt when the mind enjoys a serene consciousness of the divine presence and favour,

it is the result of evil done by us, or at least latent in us, and to which we inwardly incline.

We see also, that when we are in this state we really are in spiritual captivity: for the Moabites, being a different nation from the Israelites, though descended, but by an unlawful connexion, from the same original stock, must needs represent something of the natural man separate from the spiritual,

and, when not under the dominion of the spiritual, in opposition to it.

With respect to the man of the church, individually, by the children of Israel's doing evil in the sight of the Lord, is not meant that the man who has advanced so far in the regenerate life, as to have attained the state represented by the taking possession of Canaan, will afterwards fall into the habitual practice of gross evils, for if he did he would be guilty of profanation;

but by this circumstance is meant, that the man in this state makes a new discovery of some evil tendencies in his nature which he had not been aware of before, and comes into temptation by the excitement of evils to which, of himself, he inclines, although it is in opposition to the new life of heavenly affections which reign in him from the Lord.

How far a person [who has -Ed] really advanced in the regenerate life may by any possibility be guilty

of actual evils, perhaps cannot be determined; but that he should commit any of those contained in the decalogue, in their external form, I think can scarcely be supposed.

We wish to speak with gentleness on this subject, because we should be unwilling to say any thing which might drive any one to despair; although a right apprehension of the nature of the divine laws can have no tendency to beget despair in any one,

as we are assured that it is never altogether too late to begin a new course of life, and that repentance, when of that sincere kind, which alone is called repentance in the Word, and which consists, not merely in sorrow for our sins, but in a real desisting from and forsaking them -

- that such repentance will always avail in procuring for the sinner a lot in the heavenly kingdom.

But we still think it may with certainty be affirmed, that none who is subject to lapses into gross evils, can have previously attained any advanced state in the regenerate life;

wherefore if any such have fancied so, let them from the circumstance learn humility, and be content to take the lowest place, with gratitude that such a place is still left for their attainment.

To steal, to lie, to commit adultery, and the like, are evidently crimes which belong only to those who have not entered on a religious life at all, and they must be abstained from before we can advance into the lowest degree of preparation for heaven. But there are many things which are less taken notice of, which nevertheless must be surmounted before we can attain any elevated state in that progress.

How much is to be done and endured before our tempers, for instance, are so regulated, as never to betray any indications of dispositions contrary to charity and humility;

and even when they are so regulated as never to exhibit the presence of improper affections, how much more is yet to be done before the mind is altogether so free from the influence of such affections,

as to be relieved from the necessity of keeping a constant watch over the tempers, in consequence of a renewal of the will itself, so that improper influences can no longer exert a power within us.

Thus there are innumerable things in us which at first are little noticed either by ourselves or by others, which yet, as our perception of spiritual goodness and truth becomes more acute, assume in our estimation the form of most serious evils, and are such in reality, because they are connected, as is then plainly discovered, with evil lusts that have a very deep seat in our selfish nature.

Besides, we know that all the divine commandments have three distinct senses, a natural, a spiritual, and a celestial, and we shall find in ourselves propensities that are opposed to the two latter, long after an obedience to them in their literal sense has become habitual and easy.

It is easy then to see how the candidate for heaven, and who is preparing for a superior station therein, will find such passages as that now before us, applicable to his state, long after he has learned to desist entirely from such outward conduct as a common observer can condemn as criminal.

With respect to the particular nature of the state represented by a captivity under the king of Moab, this may, in some measure, be apprehended by those who are acquainted with the views which we

have formerly endeavoured to develop on the character of those who are represented by Moabites in the Holy Word.

In brief, the Moabites are they, who, while they profess a general respect for the things of the church, adulterate the good of the church by separating it from its truth, considering mere natural affection, separate from an attention to the requirements of the Holy Word, as sufficient for salvation.

It is interesting to observe here the marriage of goodness and truth which every where prevails throughout the Holy Word, by virtue of which no sooner is good the subject treated of, than something immediately follows respecting truth, and vice versa.

Thus, as was noticed in our preceding discourse, the captivity of the Israelites under the king of Mesopotamia, denotes a state in which knowledges of truth alone are prized and sought after, but which knowledges are in reality falsified in consequence of being separated from the good and love and life with which they should be united.

So now, the captivity under the king of Moab represents a state the counterpart of this, in which good alone is extolled as being all that is requisite to constitute the church in man, but in which, as the good is separate from truth, it is mere blind natural affection, defiled by a mixture with the evils of the selfhood.

There is reason to believe that the state represented by Moab is one which abounds very much in the church at this day. The numerous good humoured men of the world, who trouble themselves little about matters of doctrine, but pride themselves upon being good sort of people, friendly in their general manners, and capable of feeling the more amiable affections of the natural man, may probably be in general considered as spiritual Moabites.

And the man of the true church falls under the dominion of the Moabites, when he suffers his regard to spiritual views and ends to become quiescent, and conforms himself too far to the manners of the world.

The king of Moab however, was unable, it appears, to subdue the Israelites with his own forces alone, but he called in the assistance of the Ammonites and the Amalekites. The Ammonites, whose ancestor was brother to the ancestor of the Moabites, represent a falsification of truth corresponding with that adulteration of good which is denoted by the Moabites.

What the specific character of the falsified truth represented by the Ammonites is, I know not that we have sufficient grounds for determining; but I have often thought that the worship of their idol, the horrid Moloch, in honour of whom his worshipers threw their children into the flames, is an apt emblem of the Deity worshiped by those who believe the doctrine of predestination, and suppose that man's eternal state is determined by an eternal decree which no efforts on his part can get revoked, and in consequence of which the greater portion of mankind are unalterably destined to eternal fire.

The Amalekites, again, denote a false persuasion of a very deep nature, grounded in interior evil, or in the deep-seated evil propensities of the natural man.

The nature of this may be gathered from the first place where the Amalekites are mentioned, which is

in the 17th of Exodus, where it is said that the Amalekites came and fought with Israel in Rephidim. Now this attack of the Amalekites upon the Israelites, took place immediately after the latter had undergone the temptation from the want of water at Massah and Meribah; and by the assault of the Amalekites afterwards is meant a false persuasion arising in the mind, and suggesting to the man that it is in vain for him to persevere in his spiritual course, for that it consists of nothing but trials, in some or other of which he must inevitably be lost.

The Amalekites, however, were then conquered by the holding up of Moses' hands, to denote, that while we keep all the powers of the mind elevated to the Lord we shall be secured from every danger, and from the assaults even of despair; from being depressed by any suggestion that may present itself respecting the difficulty and danger of the path to heaven.

These united forces then came and smote the city of palm trees, which was a name given to Jericho, and which probably, after the destruction of Jericho, was a place in its vicinity. The situation of this city, at the entrance of the land of Canaan, shows it to be the principle whereby there is introduction into the church, which is by the doctrine of truth from good;

wherefore to smite this city is to deprive this doctrine of its power, and thereby to prevent any thing from flowing from the spiritual mind into the natural.

By the doctrine of truth from good, is meant not a mere principle of doctrine by itself, but a doctrine so combined with affection for the duties which it prescribes, as to be determined forcibly into life and practice.

The nature of this principle, however, will be more easily seen, when we come to describe, in another discourse, what is represented by Ehud, who was raised up as a deliverer on this occasion. Suffice it to say, that when the truths we know, or the doctrines we profess, have no determination to life and practice, they are of no avail whatever in promoting or maintaining our state in the spiritual life. The communication is then cut off between the internal man and the external; and such principles as are represented by the Moabites, the Ammonites, and the Amalekites sway the mind, and threaten the extinction of every spiritual attainment and heavenly hope and prospect.

From this brief view of the invasion of Eglon and its consequences, we see the importance of ever watching against the yielding in any degree, to the suggestions of the natural man in any of his allurements to evil. If the children of Israel had not done evil in the sight of the Lord, Eglon would have had no power to hurt them; but when this is done in any degree, our security against infernal influences is gone, and nothing but such a repentance as is described in the next verse, and which we shall consider in our next discourse, can save us from ruin.

Sermon VI. Judges 3:15-21

"But when the children of Israel cried unto the Lord, the Lord raised them up a deliverer, Ehud the son of Gera, a Benjamite, a man left-handed: and by him the children of Israel sent a present unto Eglon the king of Moab. But Ehud made him a dagger which had two edges of a cubit length; and he did gird it under his raiment, upon his right thigh. And he brought the present unto Eglon king of Moab: and Eglon was a very fat man. And when he had made an end to offer the present, he sent away the people that bare the present. But he himself turned again from the quarries that were by Gilgal, and said, I have a secret errand unto thee, O king: who said, Keep silence. And all that stood by him went out from him. And Ehud came unto him: and he was sitting in a summer parlour, which he had for himself alone. And Ehud said, I have a message from God unto thee. And he arose out of (his) seat. And Ehud put forth his left hand, and took the dagger from his right thigh, and thrust it into his belly." (Judges 3:15-21)

We have already, in our last discourse, considered the state of captivity into which the Israelites had fallen to Eglon the king of Moab, as related in the three verses which precede those just read; and the means of their deliverance from which are described in the singular history which we have now taken for our text.

We have seen that, when understood in its spiritual sense, according to the relation which it bears to the advancement of an individual member of the Lord's church in the regeneration, it describes a state of temptation which is incurred, in consequence of the opening of a new depth in the corrupt part of the human mind, in which the man is infested by the predominance of merely natural ends and objects,

such as are regarded by those who entertain the persuasion that natural goodness alone will suffice for their salvation, and under the influence of which he is in danger of becoming a mere man of the world.

We, in the same discourse, also offered some observations with a view of guarding the inexperienced mind from concluding that regeneration must be a state unattainable,

if such a boundless variety of distinct steps are included in it,

by shewing that provided we are attentive in the performance of the two conditions on which alone it depends: which are, to acknowledge and ever look to the Lord alone, and to obey His commandments, we may rely upon being led safely on, whether we have any very distinct views of the roads, and places of sojourning, or not.

But it may be asked, If this is all that is absolutely necessary on our parts, what need to be prying into these deep mysteries? And if but few attain the degree of advancement internally described in the book of Judges, what use can it be to us to know any thing of its nature?

Both these questions may be answered by observing, that, as it is absolutely necessary to advance in the regeneration at all, we should learn to look to the Lord and keep his commandments; it is also necessary that all religious instruction and exhortation, especially that delivered from the pulpit, should ever keep these objects in view.

But always to dwell upon them in their simplest form only, would become tedious by its sameness and by the frequent repetitions to which we must have recourse; all which are avoided by unfolding passages of the Word which have reference properly to distinct states;

whilst the same end is obtained when it is shown, as every part of the Word must show, that the same general lesson results from them all.

Surely the necessity of acknowledging the Lord and keeping His commandments must press upon us with tenfold force, when we thus find it meeting us, as it were, at every corner.

As observed on former occasions, although the states to be passed through at different periods have specific differences, yet they have general similitudes: and thus from a description of what takes place in a higher state, we may derive instruction suited to our improvement in a lower.

In, the second place it may be observed, that knowledge respecting states beyond those which we may at present have attained, ought surely to be as delightful to the mind intent upon spiritual improvement, as knowledge respecting remote countries or objects is found to be to the students of natural science. To acquire information respecting the remote countries on this globe, the nature of their soil and productions, and the manners of their inhabitants, is found to be a wish so congenial to human nature, that many expeditions, attended with great danger and expense, have been fitted out with this object alone.

Nor is the love of knowledge, so natural to man, satisfied with learning what is to be seen, and is contained in the whole of the earth we inhabit; but it has pushed its researches into other worlds, and seeks information, not only respecting the planets which belong with our own earth, to the same solar system, but respecting the other "systems distant far, spread through the boundless skies."

Numerous are the ways in which the ingenuity of man has been exerted to gratify this thirst; and the little which has thus been discovered respecting the innumerable systems of worlds and of suns which every where fill the regions of interminable space, is prized in proportion to the difficulties which lay in the way of its attainment.

Now surely it should not be said, that in this respect the children of this world are wiser than the children of light. Surely some acquaintance with the more advanced states in the course of the regeneration, being what we all may,—and ought to,—desire to attain, ought to be far more interesting to us, than the knowledge of remote countries and distant worlds, where they never can go, are found to the disciples of natural science.

And if such attainments in natural science, though not conducive to any immediate use, are still highly beneficial by their tendency to enlarge the faculties of the mind, and by the light they often throw upon things of more direct utility, doubtless the study of such subjects as we have been speaking of, must improve the mind in general, and tend to throw light upon subjects connected with our immediate states, in a far higher proportion.

Besides, though we have remarked that but few can have really entered into the states described in the historical relations we are at present considering, yet we cannot say but that some may have done so. Let us then endeavour to enlarge our views of spiritual subjects by the occasional contemplation of

such as we have been speaking of;

but let us, whatever our own state may be, endeavour to render such contemplations truly profitable to us, by appropriating the incentives which they afford to a more earnest pursuit of heavenly objects, to a more entire rejection of evil from the heart and life,

a more faithful cultivation of the truly saving principles of love and charity, a more complete confidence in the Lord's mercy and assistance, and a more settled habit of keeping the mind elevated continually to Him, with that interior prayer which opens it for the reception of blessings from Him.

The subject however which is at present before us, while it shows in what manner the state in the regenerating individual represented by the captivity of the Israelites under Eglon, is terminated,

also shows how judgment is performed on such persons as are represented by Eglon and the Moabites, when they have so filled up the measure of their iniquity as entirely to have separated themselves from all connection with the heavenly kingdom, and thus to be beyond the sphere of divine protection.

We will therefore, by way of varying the scene, consider it chiefly in this reference, which is a very awful and impressive one;

but first to continue the connection of the subject in the other point of view, we will as briefly as possible, touch upon the relation of the history to individual states.

As we have before shown that the Moabites, in a general sense, represent those who, without much regard to the spiritual things of the church, think to be saved merely in consequence of possessing some amiable dispositions from nature, it of course follows, that when applied to the states of the regenerating member of the church, they must represent the tendency to such a persuasion existing in every human mind, — or those principles in the constitution of the natural man, which, if allowed to obtain the decided rule within us, would make us altogether of this character ourselves.

The nature of this principle, and the kind of adulteration of good which it induces, we have considered at large on former occasions.

Ehud, then, by whom the deliverance of the Israelites was effected, must of course signify something directly the reverse of this — that kind of good which is not the spurious offspring of mere nature, but such as results from bringing the truths of the Word into the life; the good actions springing from whence are not the offspring of a blind impulse, but of an enlightened apprehension of the will of the Lord; being what is sometimes called in the New Church Writings, "truth in act".

As this might be inferred from the character of the enemies to whom Ehud was opposed, so is it rendered certain by the information which is given respecting his family; for it is said that he was a Benjamite; of course he must represent some specific heavenly grace of the same general character, which is represented by Benjamin the founder of his tribe; and what this is, is made evident in the history of Joseph and his brethren.

When Joseph was ruler over the land of Egypt, he represented the celestial internal within the natural; and his brethren, by whom he had been sold into slavery, and who had even entertained the thought of

killing him, represented the truths of the church as first existing in the external man,

in which though they are the offspring of the internal, they at first appear in the shape of the mere knowledges of heavenly things, and being as yet only conjoined with such affections as belong to the external man, they are unwilling to become obedient to the pure affections of the internal, represented by Joseph.

At last however, this takes place, but not until a real disposition is felt to bring into life whatever is known respecting spiritual subjects from the Lord. This is the only medium by which the internal man and the external can be conjoined; and this is what is represented by Benjamin.

This, then, is the reason why, notwithstanding the penitence which Joseph's brethren manifested for their former ill-treatment of him, he did not discover himself to them until they brought with them Benjamin. Thus Benjamin represents truth in act; which is a disposition and determination in the external man to bring into practice the heavenly will of the internal; and when this exists in the external, the external and internal can be in conjunction, and not before.

Now, as Benjamin denotes a principle of action in the external from the internal, we see the propriety of its being said that Ehud, who delivered the Israelites from the oppression of the king of Moab, was a Benjamite.

For the king of Moab, we have before seen, represents a principle of seeming, but not genuine, good that is of the natural or external man alone; and he acquires an influence in the mind by obtaining possession of the city of palm trees; by which is represented the shutting up of the communication between the spiritual man or mind and the natural, or the internal and the external.

Deliverance then from a domination of this kind, must needs be effected by opening with power, a principle in the mind by which the communication between the internal and external is restored, and the natural man seeks to do good from the spiritual, and not from itself alone.

This then is what is represented when it is said, that the Lord raised up for them a deliverer, Ehud the son of Gera, a Benjamite. It denotes the opening in the natural man, by a strong influx from the spiritual, and from the Lord Himself, who is inmosty present therein, of a determination to bring into practice all the divine commandments,

and the fixing in the mind of a steady principle, of which this is always the tendency and object.

When this is fully formed within us, the tyranny of Moab cannot last much longer. So long as light from the internal man,—or what amounts to the same, from the Lord Himself through heaven,—is shut out, it may be possible to imagine that the exercise of the more amiable of the natural affections, may be sufficient to qualify us for heaven, and even that the indulgence of any of the impulses which have a basis in our natural dispositions will not exclude us.

but when the communication between the internal man and the external is open, in which case the rational faculty is truly enlightened, it is seen that all good, to be genuine, must have respect to eternal considerations and to the Lord Himself, and that,

in reality, no good that may appear such outwardly, is such inwardly, except so far as evils are resisted and held in abhorrence as sins against God.

A determination inspired by the Lord, continually to act under the influence of these convictions, is what is represented by Benjamin in the Holy Word, except when he is described as being in a state of rebellion; and the specific application of this general principle to the removal of the influence of the evil represented by the Moabites, is what is denoted by his descendant Ehud.

This signification of Benjamin is the reason that he is the last of the tribes mentioned as being sealed in their foreheads, in the Revelation, where, as explained in the New Church Writings, he signifies the life of truth resulting from the doctrine of good and truth that will prevail in the New Church; he also there signifies the conjunction of those who are in the ultimate heaven with the Lord, which evidently must arise from their being in a life according to such doctrine.

We see then, my brethren, of what indispensable moment it is to cherish in the mind, not merely the knowledges of truth, an acquaintance with the doctrines of the Church, but a fixed determination, living by an inward communication with the Lord, to bring such knowledges into life and activity.

Without this, we shall be disposed to rest in mere doctrine alone, and shall hold the highest truths in all the harsh, unhallowed spirit of the open advocate of the doctrine of faith alone.

When we hear that pure spiritual love must be exalted to the dominion within us; that a heavenly Joseph, who represents the spiritual principle in general, — which is pure truth united with good and manifesting itself in the affections of charity, — must take the lead within us, we shall be disposed to resist, and even to extinguish this heavenly principle altogether;

nor can our knowledges of truth be conjoined with this, their proper internal, until a Benjamin is established as a medium to unite them; — until there exists a firm determination of our truths to life.

This is a state which must take place early in the regenerate life, as it belongs to the process by which man is regenerated as to the first or spiritual-natural degree. The effects of it will, however, be experienced through all the states that will succeed: for when a Benjamin is thus found to unite the internal with the external in the natural degree, an Ehud may afterwards be raised up further to extend this union, to liberate us from Moabitish domination, and to prepare the natural man for still further improvement under the influence of the genuine celestial.

With respect to the manner in which the operations are carried on in the interiors of the mind, to effect the removal thence of the corrupt principle represented by Eglon and the establishment of the heaven-derived determination to good conduct, represented by Ehud in its place, information is afforded in the remainder of our present text.

To elucidate this fully, would require several discourses, which would be inconsistent with the plan at present proposed; we will, therefore, only explain some of the leading particulars in a very brief manner. And as, when brevity is an object, they admit more easily of an explanation of a general nature as referring to the divine judgments really incurred by those who are spiritually Moabites, it is in this point of view that we will consider them.

It will be easy for every one to make the application to individual states, by remembering that in this view, both Moabites and Israelites represent certain principles abiding in the mind of the regenerating subject, whereas in the general application, the Moabites represent those persons who are confirmed in the kind of adulteration of good which has been before described, and the Israelites represent those who are the true members of the church; and in this case, Ehud will represent the Lord Himself as to that principle in the Divine nature from which the faithful are rescued, and the evil of this quality are separated from heaven and left to sink into the infernal dungeons, which are the native seats of the motives and ends of life which they have made their own.

It appears then, that judgment comes upon the wicked of this description at the time of their receiving a present from the Israelites; by which is denoted their arrogant persuasion that their pretended good is the real good of the church, and that all the truths of the Word ought to be so explained as to confirm that it is so.

For the Moabites to exact a present or tribute from the Israelites, is to apply the holy things of the church to confirm their ruling principle; and when this is done by the wicked, as it always is when they are confirmed in their evil state, in spirit, at least, if not in outward form, its effect is, entirely to close heaven against them, and to render them liable to the destruction which awaits all who are not protected by the reception of some degree of spiritual life through heaven from the Lord.

By Ehud, who slew the king of Moab, being said to be a man left-handed, or as it is given literally in the margin, "shut of his right hand," that is, having no use of his right hand, is described the appearance to those who are in evil, as if the Lord as to His Divine Truth had no power to hurt them — the right hand always denoting power.

By Ehud's dagger with two edges, is meant the divine truth proceeding from the Lord to execute judgment upon those who are in evils and falsities, — the two edges are expressly mentioned, to denote that the divine truth of the Word is equally opposed to both.

By its being concealed under his raiment, is denoted that divine truth in the letter of the Word does not appear to be of such a quality, since the evil can falsify it to serve their own purposes, when nevertheless it is; indeed it is in consequence of their falsifying the Word, that it becomes a sharp sword, cutting them off from all communication with the heavenly kingdom.

By his bringing the present to Eglon is meant, as before, the assumption by the wicked of supremacy over the things of the church, and their making them seem to favour their loves; and Eglon is here said to be a very fat man, to denote the deep degree of adulteration of all genuine good which is in this state incurred.

By Ehud's sending away the people that were with him, is signified the Lord's care, when judgment is performed, that they who are really in truths should not be hurt, and the cutting off of communication between them and the evil to secure this object.

By Ehud's returning, and coming to the king of Moab in a summer parlour which he had for himself alone, is expressed the deep exploration of the interior state of the evil at the time of judgment, when all their exteriors, in which they appeared outwardly like upright members of the church, are stripped

away, and their inmost hidden quality, which is altogether wicked and profane, is detected by the piercing light of divine truth.

By Ehud's then putting forth his left hand, is meant the judgment then performed as from truth alone, which, separated from its good, of which the wicked are not receptive, condemns all to hell; that nevertheless this proceeds from divine good in the Lord, is meant by his taking his dagger from his right thigh; and by his thrusting it into his [Eglon's] belly, is described the entrance of truth in this separated state, which deprives the wicked of the appearance of spiritual life which they had before assumed, and leaves them no refuge but in the abodes of death eternal.

Here then, my brethren, we see how awful is the state of those who so submit themselves to the bondage of the king of Moab as to become of the same character themselves. But we see also, that if, on discovering in our own selfish nature, the tendencies to such a state, we strive to resist them, and with this view look to the Lord and live according to his commandments, he will remove from us the infernal powers by whose agency such evils are excited, and will, by the same power of his Divine Truth quickened within us, restore us to genuine liberty, and light, and life.